

Gell-Mann Amnesia

MICHAEL CRICHTON EARNED his M.D. from Harvard Medical School—but he never practiced medicine. Instead, he wrote novels and screenplays. His first book was *The Andromeda Strain* in 1969, which became a movie in 1971. He wrote (and occasionally directed) other famous works, notably *Westworld* (1973), *Coma* (1978), *Jurassic Park* (1990), *Rising Sun* (1992), and *The Lost World* (1995). He was also the creator of the long-running television series *ER* (1994–2009).

In addition to being a brilliant writer, Crichton was also an astute observer of the world. His unique place in the entertainment food-chain as an author/director gave him sharp insights into mass media. He was particularly disturbed by the penchant for rank opinion mongering.

In a 2002 speech titled “Why Speculate?”¹⁰¹ Crichton observed:

Everybody knows that *Hardball*, *The O'Reilly Factor*, and similar shows are nothing but a steady stream of guesses about the future. The Sunday morning talk shows are pure speculation... But speculation is every bit as rampant in the so-called serious media, such as newspapers.

Today's media issues were visible to an insightful observer over two decades ago. Crichton's focus on “totally undeserved media credibility” fits squarely with what investors need to understand about the media they consume.

I find the affect he calls “Gell-Mann Amnesia” disturbing:

You open the newspaper to an article on some subject you know well. You read the article and see the journalist has absolutely no understanding of either the facts or the issues. Often, the article is so wrong it actually presents the story backward—reversing cause and effect. I call these the *wet streets cause rain* stories. Papers are full of them.